

Subject: Professional Ethics

Unit: Unit I

Topics: Codes of Ethics, Honesty, Self-interest

Case Study: Reusing the University Vision Model in a Commercial Drone

Group Name: Group193785

Member	Role
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Case Study Brief

This case study examines the ethical and practical challenges faced by Priya, an intern at the Tiruchirappalli Autonomous Systems Research Lab, when integrating a crop-disease vision model containing a module licensed strictly for non-commercial use into a commercial drone product by a startup. The group analyzed the conflicting obligations to original creators, the lab, the startup, and Priya's own career, and explored responsible actions amid sponsorship pressures, licensing constraints, and tight deadlines. Through role-based discussions and a collaborative group dialogue, the participants identified key ethical responsibilities and proposed a balanced approach to address the license conflict without compromising integrity or stakeholder interests.

Problem Analysis

- The lab's internal documentation inaccurately described the entire model as reusable, conflicting with the module's non-commercial license, risking unauthorized commercial use.
- The startup requires a commercial demonstration within 16 days, but replacing the restricted module would take six weeks and significant additional funding.
- Priya faces pressure from the startup's job offer contingent on successful integration, creating a personal conflict between career interests and ethical obligations.
- Failure to address the license conflict transparently could expose all parties—creators, lab, startup, and students—to legal, reputational, and financial risks.

Methodology

- Role-based ethical analysis with participants representing the faculty lead, startup compliance representative, and the intern to explore multiple perspectives.
- Detailed review of licensing terms, project timelines, funding sources, and stakeholder obligations to identify conflicts and responsibilities.
- Facilitated group discussion to harmonize individual viewpoints into joint recommendations emphasizing transparency, compliance, and protection of stakeholders.
- Application of ethical codes focusing on honesty, intellectual property respect, and balancing self-interest against institutional and creator rights.

Key Findings

- The lab holds responsibility for correcting inaccurate documentation and preventing unauthorized commercial use, regardless of good faith assumptions.
- The startup must independently verify license permissions and avoid commercial use without explicit written consent from the original creators.
- Priya must prioritize professional integrity by disclosing the license conflict, refusing unauthorized integration, and supporting lawful alternatives despite career pressures.
- A temporary, clearly labeled research-only demonstration may be ethically permissible if strictly separated from commercial activities and permitted by the license.

Recommendations

- Pause any commercial use of the restricted module until obtaining explicit written permission or developing a fully licensed replacement.
- Implement transparent documentation and communication procedures involving all parties, including protecting Priya from pressure or retaliation.
- Establish clear accountability within the lab for maintaining accurate software licensing records and review processes before labeling software as reusable.
- Provide documented commitments from the startup to maintain student stipends and support during any project delays, alongside independent reporting channels for ethical concerns.

Conclusions

The case underscores the paramount importance of respecting intellectual property rights and maintaining professional integrity in research collaborations, even under significant commercial and personal pressures. By prioritizing transparent communication, lawful compliance, and stakeholder protection, the lab, startup, and Priya can navigate licensing conflicts responsibly. The agreed safeguards and role-based accountability provide a framework to uphold ethical standards while seeking practical solutions that preserve funding, project viability, and career opportunities without compromising legal or moral obligations.